

up from time to time,” says Altaf, a Net junkie and founder of Infopimps.

A Web community is not very different from the ones in the real world. They are similar in terms of their social dynamics. Both involve developing a web of relationships among people who have something in common, ranging across the spectrum from a hobby, a life-altering illness, a political cause, a religious conviction, a professional relationship, or even socialising. The environment is electric, and the people are real.



Newsgroups

Newsgroups are a cross between public message boards and e-mail lists. You have to subscribe to a newsgroup and sometimes only subscribers can post a message. The different newsgroups are arranged according to a branching hierarchy. The main branches (alt, biz, comp, misc, rec, sci, soc, and talk) have their own sub branches.

To read newsgroup messages, you need a newsgroup reader. Often, these come with your browser (Netscape Messenger for instance) or your e-mail software (Microsoft Outlook). Subscribe to the newsgroup, download the ‘headers’ or title lines, and then read as many or as few of the actual messages as you choose.

DejaNews is a searchable archive of thousands of different newsgroups. If you want a flavour of newsgroup life, take a look there.

A worldwide system of discussion groups called Usenet is the most abundant source of communities. Whatever the topic, you’ll find a newsgroup devoted to it. You post a message to a newsgroup and come back later to see if you’ve received an answer. Usenet is a near-anarchic, censorship-resistant, aggressively non-commercial entity that has generated more than 500 million messages in the last 15 years. Usenet has grown from its Unix background of programmers and network administrators and now reaches out to governments, mass media and financial circles.

- ✓ Simple to participate in
- ✗ Difficult to administer
- ✗ Heavily spammed

Log a Blog

Web logs are an interesting Net phenomenon. They are like traditional diaries, offering regular updates on the blogger’s life. Still others are guided tours of the Web, offering links to noteworthy stories, sites and links to other blogs. Often what is written in them is of an intensely personal nature—not exactly the kind of things you’d tell someone the first time you met them. Yet these people share it with the world, as if there was no such thing as a secret.

Anyone with a Net connection and a computer can set up their own Web log at **Blogger.com**.

The most dedicated diarists—those with massive hits and the most links to

their sites—reach thousands of people each day. Their sites tend to combine the writing talent and insight of traditional columnists with the Web’s informality.

One such popular blogging service, with a strong Indian subcommunity is **Livejournal**, a free service that allows users to keep and constantly update a Web journal. **Livejournal** allows private and public entries, and has a feature where you can set up a circle of friends. This is a great way to catch up with friends and acquaintances if you lead a rushed life. Each blogger can even maintain a friends list, so that you can see what your friends are doing, at a glance.



Forums and discussion groups

Discussion groups linked to a specific Web site are quickly becoming the standard for site-based virtual communities. As in e-mail and newsgroups, you post a message to a discussion group and read the response later.

You can participate in Web-based discussion groups on any site that hosts one, and even build your own either by hosting it yourself or by using one of the many free discussion group tools such as EzBoard. EzBoard is the leading online community service on the Net, with over 1 million communities created and over 8 million registered users. You can use EzBoard to add a free message board service as a seamless addition to your Web site.

Forums foster a tight community where conversations are more focused than you’d typically find on Usenet and e-groups. Forums require the reader to visit a Web page to read (and reply) to messages. It’s also a more ‘passive’ technique—discussion forums sit there waiting for someone to show up to read and post comments.

- ✓ Great for social conversation and in-depth discussion of issues one considers important

- ✓ One can often see a number of messages on one HTML page

- ✗ Difficult to come to some kind of resolution of the ongoing discussion
- ✗ Difficult to find specific information at a later date



Chat rooms

Chat rooms are the quickest way to connect with people on the Net. Besides traditional chat rooms, there are rooms where you can move through a graphical world and others where you can build your own text-based world.

Messages exchanged in chat rooms are usually limited to one-liners. They are best used for social purposes and not for exchange of information and views. Some online communities have chat based on IRC, which allows more or less universal access; even a Java applet can get you connected to a chat channel.

- ✓ Real-time discussions
- ✓ One can log the transcript to be posted later
- ✗ Difficult to schedule a time if you have users from around the globe
- ✗ To be useful, it needs a dedicated group of users

